

HIGH SCHOOLS / TOURNAMENT BASKETBALL

Olmsted Falls stays in control to down Bay, 56-43

By DENNIS MANOLOFF
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

The Olmsted Falls Bulldogs gave themselves a break last night. They didn't have to work overtime for a postseason victory.

Behind overpowering pivot play from Tim Schaefer and a solid defense, Olmsted Falls defeated Bay, 56-43, in a Division II boys district final basketball game at Baldwin-Wallace College.

The Bulldogs (17-6) advance to the Toledo Regional, where they will play the Ashland District winner Tuesday.

Before opposing the Rockets, Olmsted Falls' tournament run

had featured defeats of Firelands in overtime and Rocky River in double overtime.

"I told the kids after the Rocky River game that we're not doing this OT stuff anymore," Bulldogs coach Pat Donahue said. "If so, I'm going to sit in the stands."

"I know I have more gray hairs as a result, but right now, it's worth it."

Olmsted Falls is in the regionals for the third time in six seasons under Donahue. It has twice lost a regional semifinal.

"They have what it takes to keep going," Bay coach Dick Scott said.

Scott, perhaps better than any

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coach, would know. The Rockets, who finished 13-10 in his first season, went 0-3 against their Southwestern Conference rivals. Each time, they struggled against a decidedly taller Bulldogs front line led by Schaefer.

A 6-7 junior, Schaefer had a game-high 13 points and 17 rebounds, seven of which were on offense. He finished the sectional-district tournament with 64 points and 45 rebounds in three games.

Schaefer, assisted by 6-7 pivot man Nick Neumeister and 6-2 for-

ward Jerome Moore, helped Olmsted Falls outrebound Bay, 35-24. The total included a 13-4 advantage on the offensive glass.

To keep the Bay defense honest, guard Matt Tabar made four 3-pointers. They accounted for all 12 of his points.

"When those two are working like that, it gives us a nice inside-outside combination," Donahue said. "Their defense can't focus on one guy."

The Olmsted Falls defense, primarily man-to-man, did a solid job focusing on everybody. It limited the Rockets to 17-of-44 shooting from the floor. Bay, known for its 3-point marksman-

ship, made just 5-of-21 from that distance.

"We did a heckuva job defensively on them," Donahue said. "They're a good shooting team, a team that likes to dribble-penetrate and kick-out."

"We did a good job recovering on that. And, we got them to take a few bad shots and limited them to one shot on a lot of possessions."

Olmsted Falls, under the direction of smooth point guard Chris DeLisio, never was tied or trailed after a Tabar 3-pointer made it 9-6 with four minutes left in the first quarter. The Bulldogs led, 20-10, after one.

Bay, paced by Michael Master-

son, rallied to close within 32-26 at halftime. Masterson made a spectacular tip-in at the buzzer for his eighth and ninth points.

But the Bulldogs, using a 9-2 run to begin the second half, led by at least nine the remainder of the game.

Masterson finished tied with Bob Miller with a team-high 11 points. Masterson, one of the best all-around athletes the school has produced, played his final basketball game at Bay.

"He's the heart and soul of our team, and I'm going to miss him," said Scott, full of emotion. "I tell you, I'm going to miss all six of our seniors. They are six quality people — not just athletes."

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Lorain reigns

Steelmen upset Lakewood, 43-40

By JACK McDERMOTT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Lorain High's "Magic Carpet Ride" took a giant stride forward last night as the fourth-seeded Steelmen beat top-seeded Lakewood, 43-40, to win the Midwest Division I boys district tournament.

The Steelmen (17-6) advance to the Division I regional at Cleveland State to meet Euclid on Wednesday night. Lakewood closed its season 18-5.

"Our kids are on a mission," Lorain first-year coach John Rositano said. "They simply refuse to lose, and you can see it in their eyes. Have you ever seen such school support? The entire Lorain community is rallying around this team, and the kids refuse to back down from anyone."

The doors at Lorain High will close at the end of this school year, as the Lorain system cuts back to two high schools in an effort to reduce a huge financial deficit, ending the school's illustrious 100-year plus athletic history.

"This will be our first regional appearance ever, in the modern era" Rositano said. "The school won a state basketball title in 1923, but it wasn't the same play-off structure back then."

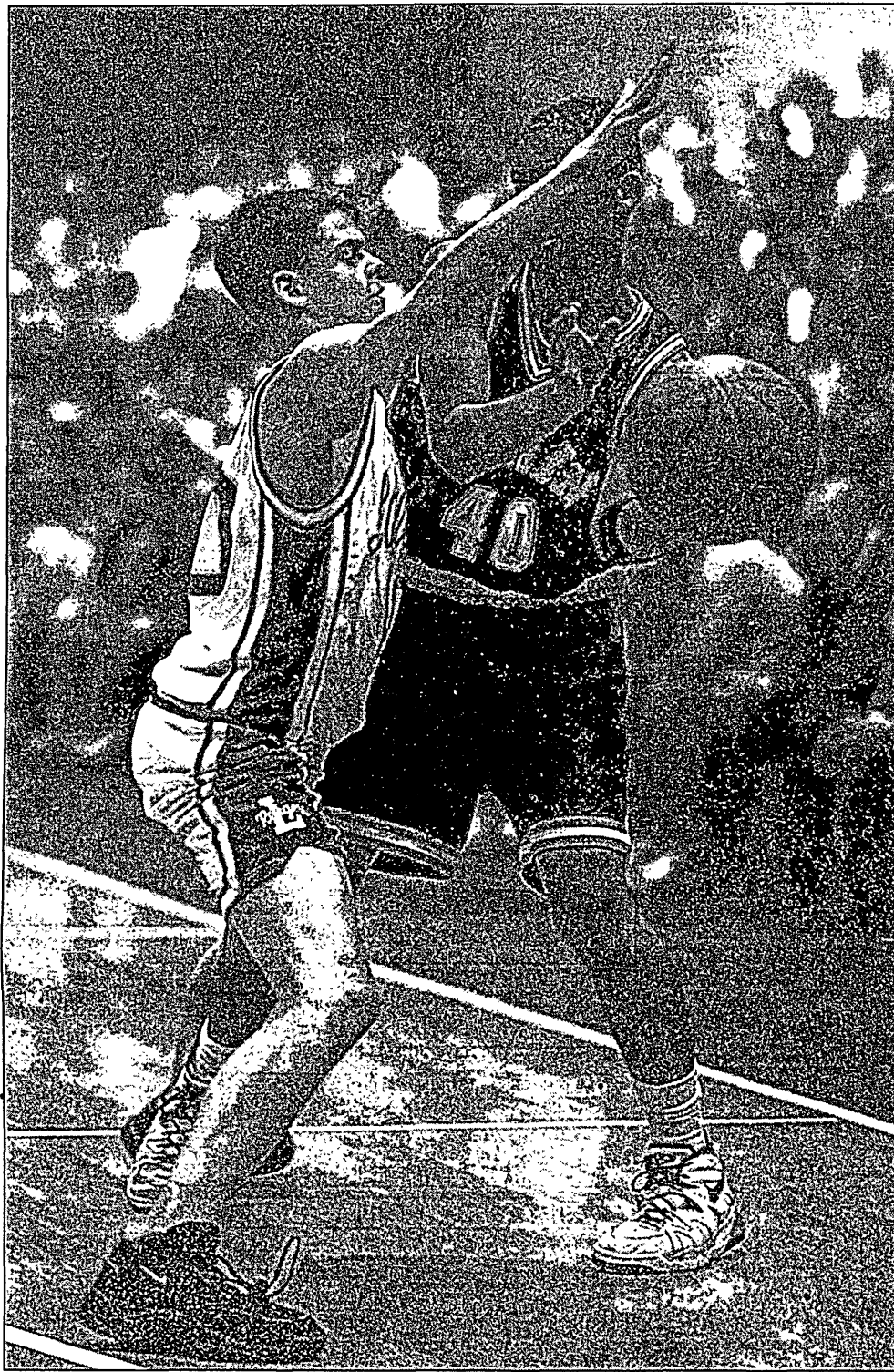
The Steelmen trailed, 19-17, at the close of the first half, then 30-27 entering the final eight minutes, before scoring the first nine points of the fourth quarter to take a 36-30 advantage with 5:30 remaining.

Joe Schwarz, a 5-9 senior, got the ball rolling for Lorain from underneath just 24 seconds into the final period, cutting Lakewood's lead to one, 30-29. Freshman Londie Ransom then put the Steelmen on top, driving the left baseline and putting in a reverse turnaround shot from the right with 6:55 remaining. Ransom was fouled on the basket and made good on the free throw, giving the Steelmen a 32-30 advantage.

Carl White, a 5-10 junior, then hit two 5-footers to push Lorain's lead to 36-30, before Lakewood's 6-5 senior Marty Budzar scored two baskets to cut Lorain's lead to 36-34 with 3:36 remaining.

Adam Lucas, a 6-5 senior, then connected on two free throws with 3:14 remaining, putting the Steelmen up by four, 38-34, before Lakewood junior Ryan Rustad connected on a 5-footer from the left, followed by a free throw by Budzar with 2:12 remaining, which cut Lorain's lead to 38-37.

Lorain's Greg Williams hit two free throws with 51 seconds to play, giving the Steelmen a 40-37 lead, only to have Lakewood's Bryan Patton, son of the Rangers' coach, hit a 3-pointer from the



Lakewood's Tom Patton pressures Londie Ransom during Lorain's 43-40 victory last night.

left baseline to tie the score, 40-40, with 33 seconds left.

White then scored the game-winner for Lorain with 18.7 seconds remaining, hitting the front end of a one-and-one for a 41-40 lead.

Lakewood brought the ball up the floor and with six seconds remaining, Patton made a break for the basket, tossing up a 5-footer from in front which fell off the rim into the hands of Lorain's Williams, who then passed it off to White, who was immediately fouled with 2.6 seconds on the

clock.

White's free throw hit the rim and fell into the waiting hands of Williams, who put it in as the buzzer sounded.

The Steelmen were led in scoring by White and Schwarz with 10 points each. Williams had nine. Lakewood was led by Patton with 16 points, including nine in the first quarter.

"This was a great defensive game, played by two great defensive teams," Lakewood coach Bob Patton said. "But it just wasn't in the cards for us. We played to the

best of our ability, as we have all season long, but down the stretch they made good on their free throws while we didn't, and that was the ballgame."

"Give them [Lorain] all the credit, they certainly deserve it. They're on a mission, and they're out there helping one another out. That's nice to see in any team. It's a sad situation for any group of young men to be in, knowing that when it's over, it's really over. I wish them nothing but the best from here on out."

Aurora tops Chanel on last-second shot

By BOB DOLGAN
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Hollywood would have rejected the plot line of roarin' Aurora's 64-63 victory over Chanel last night.

In an unbelievable finish, Gavin Sontag buried a 3-pointer at the buzzer to give Aurora, the state's top-ranked Division III team, the district championship at Lakeland Community College.

"It felt good all the way," said Sontag, who scored 18 points. "It was the biggest game of my life and the first time I've ever done anything like that. I won't be able to sleep tonight."

Sontag had made one of six 3-pointers before his big connection, which brought the Aurora rosters streaming to the floor.

"I didn't even make a three in the warmups," Sontag said. "But it was good to make it when it counted. I was thinking on the bench it would be great to hit a shot like that."

The play began with seven seconds left, after Chanel's Damon Fann had made one of two foul shots for a 63-61 lead.

After a timeout, speedy Pat Duncan, who scored 17 for Aurora, dribbled downcourt, hoping to get off a shot to tie the game.

"The play was for Pat to shoot, but I told him I'd set up for a three if he was blocked," Sontag said.

Duncan whipped the ball to Sontag on the left side, and he sent the ball in cleanly as Chanel defenders leaped at him.

"In 23 years of coaching I've never had a team win a game like that before," said Aurora coach Dan Doughman. "The closest was when I was at Holy Name and Mark Termini made a shot like that to beat St. Ignatius. But that was in the regular season. This is the farthest we've ever gone at Aurora."

"We controlled the second half," said Greg Kralej, the de-

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jected Chanel coach, whose club wound up at 17-6. "The kid got lucky and hit. It happens. If we'd made half of our foul shots, we'd have won."

Chanel sank 10 of 24 from the stripe; the Greenmen (22-1) made 13 of 19.

There was another sequence of serious melodrama prior to Sontag's shot. With eight seconds to go and Chanel leading, 62-59, Duncan was fouled while taking a 3-pointer by Fann.

He stepped to the line with a chance to tie the game and the Chanel rosters howling. Duncan quickly made his first two shots.

"I wasn't too nervous on the first one, but after I made it I got confident on the second one," said Duncan. "But on the third one, I got overconfident."

He missed the third shot and Fann grabbed the rebound. Chris Duncan, Pat's twin brother, quickly fouled Fann, who made one of the two shots, setting up Sontag's missile.

Aurora now goes to Canton to play Youngstown Mooney. "Aurora has good shooters," Kralej said. "Anytime a team has good shooters it has a chance."

The Aurora depth is a question. The Greenmen have a six-man rotation and the Duncan twins and Sontag, who have played together since the eighth grade, are on the floor almost all the time.

"It's hard to take three guys like that out," said Doughman. "They never get tired."

Chris Duncan (14 points) and Josh Jones (10) were also in double figures for Aurora. Chanel was led by point guard Izzy Santiago's 19 and 6-6 center Marques Evans' 15. Mike Monastero had 12 as the Firebirds rebounded from a 32-25 halftime deficit to go in front, 54-48, on a Monastero 3-pointer in the finale.

Euclid rallies to ground Mentor

By DON FRIEDMAN
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Mel Levett took over in the second half and carried Euclid's Panthers to a 60-56, come-from-behind victory over Mentor in the boys Division I championship basketball game in a packed Euclid gym last night.

The Panthers will take their 15-7 record to Cleveland State on Wednesday night, where they will meet Lorain (17-6) at 6:15.

It will be Euclid's first trip to a regional since the 1991-92 season. For Levett, a 6-4 senior, it will be his fourth straight regional.

"I've won two state championships in Division II, and now I would like to be on a Division I championship team," he said. "I don't think too many guys have done that."

Levett went to the state with Villa Angela-St. Joseph three times.

Last night he scored 35 points, more than half of the Panthers' total. It was in the second half that he was at his best, swishing in a long 3-pointer that gave Euclid its first lead, 49-48, with 4:45 left. It was a long one from just inside the right out-of-bounds line.

"It was a dogfight down to the final buzzer," he said.

With Jeff Woleben and Mike Calo each scoring 11 points in the first half, Mentor led at the intermission, 34-25. The Cardinals boosted their lead to 33-20 with 1:57 left in the first half.

With Levett, Larry Taylor and Clayton Cunningham supplying points in the last four minutes of the third quarter, Euclid cut the lead to three, 45-42, at the end of three quarters.

Taylor fouled out with 3:03 left and the Panthers ahead, 52-50.

"I wanted to win this game for Larry Taylor," Levett said. "I saw the look in his eye when he fouled out. He's a good friend."

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"My 3-pointers were long in the beginning," Levett said. "The coaches told me at the half to calm down. The shots will come to fall. Luckily they did start to fall. Then I got my fourth foul [with 3:51 left]. I got timid on defense, but I had to stay aggressive on offense."

John Rutkowski, Mentor's 6-4 senior, guarded Levett. Rutkowski did not score.

Cunningham guarded Jeff Woleben in the first half and held him to 11 points. Levett was on Woleben in the second half. Woleben scored 16 in the second half to lead Mentor with 27 points. The 6-3 junior Calo had 13.

"We played our starters in the second half," said Euclid coach Harold "Doc" Daugherty. "Cunningham and Taylor were in big foul trouble in the first half. Cunningham got his third foul early in the second quarter and sat until the second half."

"Cunningham and Taylor are two-thirds of our offense," Daugherty said. "We wanted to keep their lead to nine at the half."

"Then we told them we were going to cut down the nets, go to the regional and take them one basket at a time."

"Levett is such a great athlete. No one can guard him," Daugherty continued. "Even with four fouls, he stayed on his feet and did the job."

"The difference was they didn't have Cunningham and Taylor for part of the first half," said Mentor coach Bob Krizancic. "They had them in the second half. We were able to get the lead, but we missed some key one-and-ones in the fourth quarter."

"When Levett got his fourth foul, he didn't panic. He's a player. They got the lead and they got the ball into Levett's hands in the fourth quarter. We didn't want that to happen."

Twinsburg layups lead to district title

By DICK ZUNT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Twinsburg's inside work overcame Nordon's outside efforts last night in the Division II district championship basketball game in front of a packed house of 2,200 at Solon.

Twinsburg topped Nordon, 70-61, for the district title in a battle of champions.

Twinsburg is the champion of the Chagrin Valley Conference and Nordon is the champion of the Greater Cleveland Conference.

The Tigers (21-2) advanced to meet Villa Angela-St. Joseph on Tuesday at 8 p.m. in a regional semifinal at the University of Akron.

Nordon's Knights ended the season with a school-best 22-2 record.

Of the 28 2-point field goals scored by Twinsburg, 24 were layups. Three other 2-pointers did not touch the glass, but were from in close, including a slam by

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James Posey for a 55-46 lead with 5:04 left in the game.

Senior guard Kelly Herndon, who dished out nine assists, sank his team's only 3-pointer for a 42-33 lead with 5:01 left in the third quarter. Junior guard Gerry Crosby put back two field goals from in close, a jumper with 2:38 remaining in the second quarter and a short baseline jumper with 2:04 left in the game.

Nordon, which sank 10 3-pointers in its semifinal game against Trinity, made nine last night, including two each by senior John Sarver and juniors Lou Russo and Paul Rightmire.

Standing tall for the Tigers was senior forward Mark Pazdernik, who had a career high of 23 points — 22 of them on 11 layups — and added eight rebounds.

Nordon held an 18-17 lead at the end of the first quarter. Senior Anthony White drove for a layup with four seconds left in the

second quarter and Twinsburg took a 32-31 lead at halftime.

The Tigers outscored the Knights, 15-8, in the third quarter to take 47-39 lead.

A baseline jumper by Scott Boozer with three minutes left cut the Knights' deficit to 60-54, but the Knights could come no closer.

"It was a great district final, intense all the way," said Twinsburg coach Bob Pacsi, who is taking a team to the Sweet Sixteen regional level of play for the second time in three years.

"We switched into zone defenses because we picked up a lot of fouls in the first quarter," said Pacsi. "In the second half, we changed into a 1-2-2. I can't remember our having that many people in foul trouble that early in a game this season. And they were scoring quickly against us when we were in the man-for-man."

"Tonight was Mark's night," Pacsi said of Pazdernik. "He consistently got himself open for his

best game, pointwise."

"James [Posey] was trying to do too much out there and picked up two fouls in the first quarter, but after that he got rebounds on every big shot that was missed," said Pacsi. Posey wound up with 14 points and 17 rebounds.

"[Gerry] Crosby came through with some big hoops, Kelly [Herndon] wasn't getting the open shot, so he made some big assists and Anthony [White] was our glue man out there, doing a lot of things well," said Pacsi.

"To come this far and lose is tough," said Nordon coach Dave Smith. "But, in time they'll look back and know that they had a great season."

"We could never stop them," he said. "The way they penetrated, then didn't have to shoot anything but layups. Their zone got us a little off-kilter."

Mike Barrett scored 16 points for Nordon and Scott Boozer had 12.